

Critical Slowing Down

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Abstract

This project explores critical slowing down in the two-dimensional Ising model near the critical temperature T_c . Using Markov chain Monte Carlo methods, we implement both the Metropolis and Wolff algorithms to generate spin configurations and measure autocorrelation times of magnetization and energy. Magnetic susceptibility is determined with an external field B , and, in the absence of the field, via the fluctuation-dissipation theorem (FDT). The scaling of relaxation times allows estimation of the dynamic critical exponent z for each algorithm. Comparisons between local and cluster updates highlight their relative efficiency at criticality, showing how algorithmic choices affect the sampling of Markov chains in systems exhibiting critical slowing down and field-induced responses.

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1 Introduction

The Ising model is a fundamental model in statistical mechanics used to study phase transitions and critical phenomena. Despite its seemingly simple definition, including binary spin variables and nearest-neighbor interactions, it captures the essential features of spontaneous symmetry breaking and critical behaviour observed in even more complex systems. In two dimensions, the Ising model exhibits a well-known second-order phase transition at a critical temperature T_c , where various physical quantities such as magnetization, susceptibility, and correlation length display power-law divergences characterized by critical exponents.

To study both static and dynamic properties of the Ising model, Monte Carlo simulations based on Markov-chain sampling are widely used. Near the critical point, these algorithms are subject to **critical slowing down**, where the relaxation and autocorrelation time increase rapidly as the correlation length diverges. In practice, this means that successive configurations generated by the simulation become highly correlated, leading to inefficient sampling and large statistical errors. Understanding this is essential for accurate numerical studies close to T_c .

This study investigates the effective dynamics of the 2D Ising model as generated by different Monte Carlo update algorithms: the local Metropolis algorithm, which performs local single-spin updates, and the global Wolff cluster algorithm, which employs non-local cluster flips. Although both algorithms sample from the same equilibrium distribution, they impose different dynamical behaviors on the system, leading to distinct scaling behaviours of the autocorrelation time near the critical point. This scaling is characterized by the **dynamic critical exponent** z , which determines the divergence of time scales according to $\tau \sim \xi^z$ as the correlation length $\xi \rightarrow \infty$ at criticality.

The goals of this report are:

1. To derive and discuss the theoretical background of dynamic critical behaviour and the definition of the dynamic exponent z .
2. To measure autocorrelation times of magnetization and energy for both Metropolis and Wolff dynamics as the temperature approaches T_c .
3. To compare the scaling and efficiency of the two algorithms in the critical region.

Section 2 introduces the theoretical framework, including the Ising model, Monte Carlo dynamics, and the concept of dynamic scaling. Section 3 outlines the simulation methodology and measurement procedures. Section 4 presents the numerical results and analysis, while Section 5 discusses the implications of the findings and compares algorithmic performance. Finally, Section 6 summarizes the main conclusions.

2 Theoretical Background

2.1 The 2D Ising Model

The two-dimensional square-lattice Ising model is a paradigmatic system for studying phase transitions and critical phenomena. Spins $s_i = \pm 1$ occupy the sites of the $L \times L$ lattice with periodic boundary conditions (PBD) and interact with their nearest neighbors. The Hamiltonian for the system is given by:

$$H = -J \sum_{\langle i,j \rangle} s_i s_j - h \sum_i s_i, \quad (1)$$

where J is the interaction strength, h is an external magnetic field, and the sum $\langle i,j \rangle$ runs over nearest neighbor pairs.

In zero external field ($h = 0$), the model exhibits a second-order phase transition at a critical temperature T_c , separating a low-temperature ferromagnetic phase (with non-zero spontaneous magnetization) from a high-temperature paramagnetic phase (with zero magnetization). For the 2D Ising model, the critical temperature is known exactly from Onsager's solution:

$$\frac{k_B T_c}{J} = \frac{2}{\ln(1 + \sqrt{2})} \approx 2.2691853, \quad (2)$$

or equivalently,

$$J\beta_c = J \frac{1}{k_B T_c} \approx 0.4406868, \quad (3)$$

where k_B is the Boltzmann constant. [1]

The order parameter is the magnetization per spin, defined as:

$$m = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N s_i, \quad (4)$$

where $N = L^2$ is the total number of spins in the lattice.

The zero-field susceptibility χ is defined thermodynamically as:

$$\chi = \left. \frac{\partial \langle m \rangle}{\partial h} \right|_{h=0}. \quad (5)$$

By the fluctuation-dissipation theorem (FDT), this equals to

$$\chi = \beta N (\langle m^2 \rangle - \langle m \rangle^2). \quad (6)$$

In finite simulations at $h = 0$, the $\mathbb{Z}_2$ symmetry implies $\langle m \rangle = 0$ unless symmetry is explicitly broken. For thermodynamic estimates we use m in the fluctuation formula for χ , but for visualization we plot $\langle |m| \rangle$ in figures (in particular for the Wolff algorithm), since $|m|$ avoids sign cancellations and makes the ordered phase evident.

2.2 Monte Carlo Dynamics

2.2.1 Markov Chains and Master Equations

Monte Carlo updates define a Markov chain on the configuration space with a transition operator that has the Boltzmann distribution as its stationary measure. For relaxational models, such as the stochastic Ising model, the time-dependent behavior is described by a master equation

$$\frac{\partial P_n(t)}{\partial t} = - \sum_{n \neq m} [P_n(t) W_{n \rightarrow m} - P_m(t) W_{m \rightarrow n}], \quad (7)$$

where $P_n(t)$ is the probability of the system being in state n at time t , and $W_{n \rightarrow m}$ is the transition rate for $n \rightarrow m$.

The solution to the master equation is a sequence of states, but the time variable is a stochastic quantity which does not represent true time. A relaxation function $\phi(t)$ can be defined which describes time correlations *within equilibrium*

$$\phi_{MM}(t) = \frac{\langle M(0)M(t) \rangle - \langle M \rangle^2}{\langle M^2 \rangle - \langle M \rangle^2}. \quad (8)$$

When normalized in this way, the relaxation function is 1 at $t = 0$ and decays to zero as $t \rightarrow \infty$. It is important to remember that for a system in equilibrium any time in the sequence of states may be chosen as the ‘ $t = 0$ ’ state. The asymptotic, long time behavior of the relaxation function is exponential, i.e.

$$\phi(t) \rightarrow e^{-t/\tau}, \quad (9)$$

where the correlation time τ diverges as T_c is approached.

2.2.2 Dynamic Critical Phenomena

This dynamic (relaxational) critical behavior can be expressed in terms of a power law as well,

$$\tau \propto \xi^z \propto \varepsilon^{-\nu z}, \quad (10)$$

where ξ is the (divergent) correlation length, $\varepsilon = |1 - T/T_c|$, and z is the dynamic critical exponent.

In a finite system of linear size L , the divergence of the correlation length at criticality is limited by the system size. Exactly at T_c , the correlation length therefore saturates at $\xi \sim L$. Inserting this finite-size cutoff into the critical slowing-down relation $\tau \propto \xi^z$ gives

$$\tau_c \sim L^z. \quad (11)$$

Thus, at the critical temperature, the relaxation time is no longer controlled by the reduced temperature ε , but instead by the system size itself. As L increases, correlations require more time to propagate across the entire system, leading to a relaxation time that scales as a power law in L with exponent z .

A second relaxation time, the integrated relaxation time, is defined by the integral of the relaxation function

$$\tau_{\text{int}} = \int_0^\infty \phi(t) dt. \quad (12)$$

This quantity is of particular importance for the determination of errors and is expected to diverge with the same dynamic exponent as the ‘exponential’ relaxation time, as both are governed by the same long-time behavior of $\phi(t)$.

2.2.3 Error estimation

To estimate statistical uncertainties we recommend the blocking (binning) method: group consecutive measurements into blocks of size B (with $B \gg \tau_{\text{int}}$), compute the block means and use the sample variance of block means to estimate the variance of the mean. The block size should be increased until the estimated error stabilizes.

3 Methodology

3.1 Model and Setup

We simulate the ferromagnetic Ising model on a two-dimensional square lattice of linear size L with periodic boundary conditions. The number of spins is $N = L^2$, with spin variables $s_i \in -1, +1$. Throughout we set $k_B = 1$, hence $\beta = \frac{1}{T}$, and $J = 1$.

Lattice and sizes:

- $L \in [2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64, 128]$
- Periodic boundary conditions in both directions.

Temperature range:

- We scan a window around the exact critical point $\beta_c = 0.4407$, namely

$$\beta \in [0.1, 0.2, 0.3, 0.4, 0.41, 0.42, 0.43, 0.44, 0.4407, 0.45, 0.46, 0.47, 0.48, 0.49, 0.5, 0.6]$$
- For finite-size scaling at T_c , we fix $\beta = \beta_c$ and vary L .

Initialization:

- Hot (spins initialized independently to ± 1 with equal probability) and cold (all spins $+1$) starts with equal probability.

Time units:

- Metropolis: one Monte Carlo sweep (MCS) = N single-spin flip attempts.
- Wolff: one Wolff step = one cluster flip; to compare time scales, we define “Wolff sweeps” by accumulating flipped spins until the total equals N on average.

Observables:

- Energy E , magnetization M .
- For dynamic analysis: time series of M and E to compute $\rho_A(t)$, τ_{int} , and τ_{exp} .

3.2 Update Algorithms

3.2.1 Metropolis (local)

Metropolis method [2] configurations are generated from a previous state using a transition probability which depends on the energy difference between the initial and final states. The states produced follows a time ordered path, and this time is not a proper time but a Monte-Carlo time. For relaxational models, such as the stochastic Ising model, the time-dependent behavior is described by the master equation 7, with the probability of the n th state occurring in a classical system is given by $P_n = \frac{e^{-\beta E_n}}{Z}$ with Z the partition function which we don't know about. To bypass the expression of Z , we generate a Markov chain of states, i.e. we generate each new state directly from the preceding state. If we produce the n_{th} state from the m_{th} state, and then calculate the relative probability which is the ratio of the individual probabilities, the denominator cancels. As a result, only the energy difference between the two states is needed : $\Delta E = E_n - E_m$

Indeed know thanks to the master equation that in equilibrium $P_n W_{n \rightarrow m} = P_m W_{m \rightarrow n}$.

Thus

$$\frac{W_{n \rightarrow m}}{W_{m \rightarrow n}} = \frac{P_m}{P_n} = e^{-\beta \Delta E}, \quad (13)$$

and therefore,

$$W_{n \rightarrow m} = \begin{cases} \tau_0^{-1} e^{-\beta \Delta E} = e^{-\beta \Delta E} & \text{for } \Delta E > 0, \\ \tau_0^{-1} = 1 & \text{for } \Delta E \leq 0. \end{cases} \quad (14)$$

as we know that $W_{n \rightarrow m}$ is of the dimensional of 1/time and τ_0 is the time required to attempt a spin-flip that we choose equal to 1.

The steps of the algorithm are as follows:

1. Choose an initial state.
2. Choose a lattice site i .
3. Compute the energy change ΔE resulting from flipping the spin at site i .
4. Generate a random number r such that $0 < r < 1$.
5. If $r < e^{-\beta\Delta E}$, flip the spin.
6. Move to the next site and return to step (3).

3.2.2 Wolff (cluster)

Wolff proposed an alternative algorithm based on the Fortuin-Kasteleyn theorem in which single clusters are grown and flipped sequentially. The algorithm begins with the random choice of a single site. Bonds are then drawn to all nearest neighbors which are in the same state with probability

$$p = 1 - e^{-K\delta_{\sigma_i\sigma_j}}. \quad (15)$$

One then moves to all sites in turn which have been connected to the initial site and places bonds between them and any of their nearest neighbors which are in the same state with probability given by equation 15. The process continues until no new bonds are formed and the entire cluster of connected sites is then flipped. Another initial site is chosen and the process is then repeated. A single Wolff cluster update consists of the following steps:

1. Randomly select a seed spin from the lattice.
2. Grow a cluster by adding neighboring spins with the same orientation with probability $p_{\text{add}} = 1 - \exp(-2\beta J)$, where J is the nearest-neighbor coupling and $\beta = 1/T$ is the inverse temperature.
3. Repeat the cluster growth iteratively for all new cluster members until no further spins are added.
4. Flip all spins in the cluster simultaneously.

Depth-first search is used to traverse and grow the cluster efficiently. DFS avoids revisiting the same spins multiple times, making the algorithm fast even for very large clusters.

3.3 Practical Estimators and Extraction of z

To quantify critical slowing down we compute the autocorrelation function of an observable A (for instance the magnetization M , the energy or the susceptibility):

$$C_A(t) = \langle A_s A_{s+t} \rangle - \langle A \rangle^2, \quad (16)$$

and the normalized autocorrelation (autocorrelation coefficient)

$$\rho_A(t) = \frac{C_A(t)}{C_A(0)}. \quad (17)$$

A convenient scalar measure of the memory of the Markov chain is the *integrated autocorrelation time*

$$\tau_{\text{int},A} = \frac{1}{2} + \sum_{t=1}^{T_{\text{max}}} \rho_A(t), \quad (18)$$

where the sum is truncated at a cutoff T_{max} chosen e.g. by the window method (or until $\rho_A(t)$ has decayed to noise). The statistical error of a sample mean $\bar{A}$ computed from N recorded measurements is increased by autocorrelation; the effective sample size is $N_{\text{eff}} \approx N/(2\tau_{\text{int},A})$.

In practice we estimate $\tau_c(L)$ by the integrated autocorrelation time of the magnetization (or by the exponential autocorrelation time obtained from a fit of $\rho(t) \approx e^{-t/\tau_{\text{exp}}}$), and then fit $\log \tau_c$ versus $\log L$ to extract z :

$$\log \tau_c = z \log L + \text{const.} \quad (19)$$

4 Results

4.1 Equilibrium Verification

Magnetization and energy vs. temperature.

4.2 Autocorrelation Behavior

- Show sample autocorrelation functions for Metropolis and Wolff updates.
- Discuss qualitative differences: slow decay for Metropolis near T_c , fast for Wolff.

4.3 Divergence near Criticality

- Plot autocorrelation time $\tau(T)$ vs. $|T - T_c|$.
- Fit $\tau \sim |T - T_c|^{-z\nu}$ or equivalently $\tau \sim L^z$ at T_c for finite-size scaling.
- Extract dynamic critical exponents $z_{\text{Metropolis}}$ and z_{Wolff}^{**} .

Expected behavior:

- Metropolis: $z \approx 2.1$
- Wolff: $z \approx 0-0.3$

4.4 Comparison of Algorithm Efficiency

- Compare CPU time per independent sample.
- Discuss how cluster algorithms reduce critical slowing down.

5 Discussion

- Interpret differences in dynamic exponents in terms of correlation spreading mechanisms.
- Discuss limits of each approach (finite-size effects, statistical errors).
- Relate results to universality class arguments.
- Possibly mention future work or extensions (e.g., Swendsen-Wang algorithm, higher dimensions).

6 Conclusion

- Summarize key findings: - Divergence of τ near T_c ,
- Distinct dynamic exponents for different algorithms,
- Algorithmic efficiency and importance for Monte Carlo near criticality.
- Mention physical significance: critical slowing down as an emergent dynamical effect in critical systems.

References

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